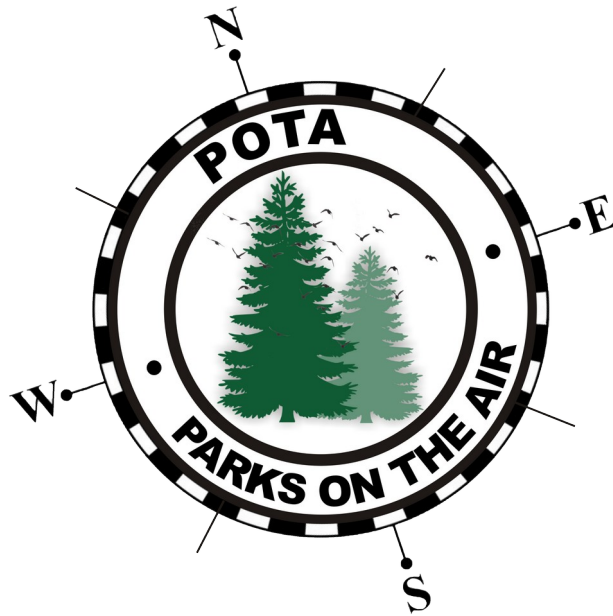




Parks on the Air Club Activation Guide

Parks on the Air SM (POTA) is an ongoing program, it encourages amateur radio operators in developing their skills, fostering community and demonstrating the hobby to the public.

There are thousands of parks available in the program worldwide and each will present a unique experience. Operating styles and seasons will also affect the nature of your experience.

Good luck!

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1 What constitutes a club activation?

Fundamentally, a club activation is multiple club members activating one or more entities as a group. This activity can be planned or ad-hoc, but generally involves groups of club members activating with the club call per the rules that the club has established for the use of it's callsign. Please be aware that for specific sponsored events, such as the summer plaque event, there may be specific requirements for the number of operators required for qualification in that specific event.

During a club activation, everyone uses the club call exclusively on air (like Field Day), and does not give out their own call¹.

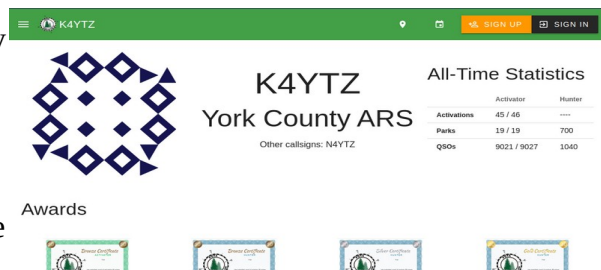
QSOs are tallied across all individual operators, however duplicate QSO rules apply based on the club call – not the operator's.

The individual members participating as operators, are not required to have their own POTA accounts, but it is encouraged.

2 Creating a POTA account for a club

Clubs participating in POTA must have an account specifically for the club; club callsigns should never be added under the profile for an individual's accounts.

Your club should have an active POTA manager, who has access to the club's account at <https://pota.app/>, can coordinate logs for the club, etc.



3 Planning the club activation

The farther in advance you can schedule the more people you can accommodate, but scheduling in advance is not a requirement for POTA. Spur of the moment activations are permitted, and are also very common. If you are planning a multiple station activation, please keep in mind that running multiple radios takes a lot of room. Since parks are public spaces, make sure you are not creating a hazard for anyone with your setup, including the RF safety aspects. More radios = more RF.

Since duplicates are be tracked across all operators using the same callsign, networked logging is highly recommended for activations with multiple stations, especially if you have stations that could operate on the same band and mode within the same park and state, as this style of activating could generate a lot of duplicate QSOs.

If you have a large number of operators, plan out operating shifts so that everyone gets a turn.

There is no “pass the mic” in a club activation since everyone is using the club call.

¹be sure to also follow FCC rules regarding privileges and control operators.

4 Day of the Activation

4.1 Spotting

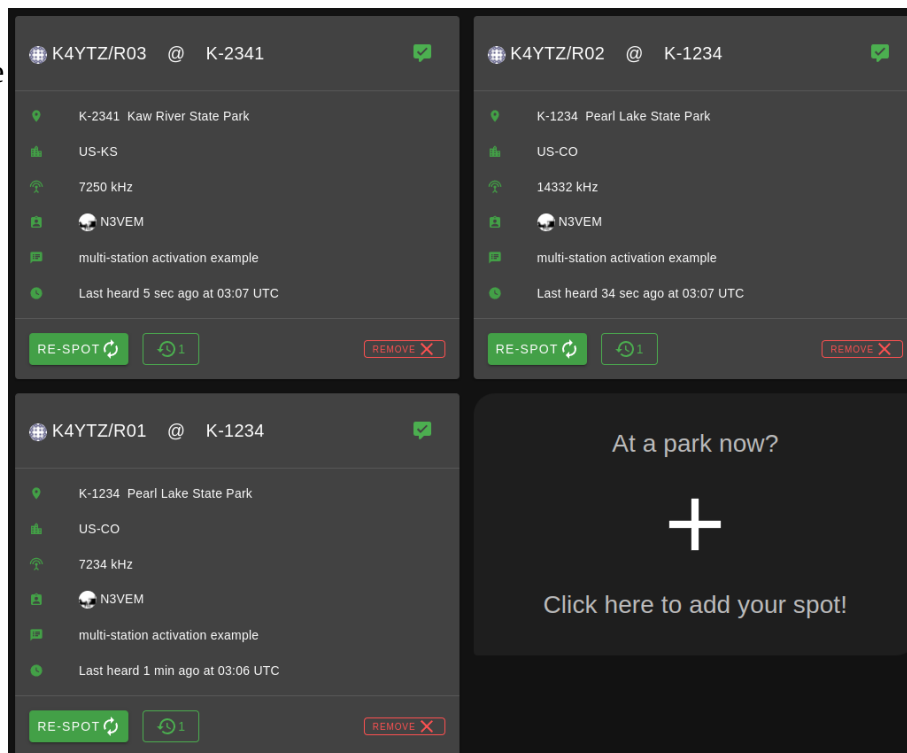
If you are only running one station, and taking turns as operators, spot as normal, using the club callsign.

If you are running multiple stations, differentiate them on the spotter using /R01, /R02, /R03, etc.

This same convention can be used if you have stations in more than one park. Just be certain to agree ahead of time which station will use which /modifier.

If you have reason too, you can use different 3 character /modifiers from the ones listed above, however following this convention should make it clear to hunters that there are multiple radios/stations running at the same time.

When exchanging callsigns over the air, the best practice is to only send the base callsign WITHOUT the tactical modifier that you are using to differentiate between multiple stations on the spotter.



4.2 Making QSOs

When it comes time to start making contacts, an excellent resource for what to do while on the air is the [On the Air section of the POTA activators guide](#).

A typical contact may sound something like this however:

Activator: CQ POTA CQ POTA This is Kilo One Uniform Bravo Calling CQ Parks on the Air.

Hunter: Whiskey Three Alpha Alpha X-ray

Activator: Whiskey Three Alpha Alpha X-ray you are five nine in K-1234

Hunter: Thanks for the five nine in K-1234, you are five seven in Florida

Activator: Thanks for the five seven in Florida, 73

Hunter: Whiskey Three Alpha Alpha X-ray 73

Note that the activator only gave the club call (K1UB) since this is a club activation. It is also strongly recommend that even if you are using /modifiers on the spotter to differentiate between multiple stations, that you ONLY exchange the base call on the air. This keeps logging and callsign management the simplest. Following standard best amateur practices, anyone that hunts you should be recording your callsign in their own logs the way you announce it over the air.

4.3 Logging

Regardless of the logging software used, the following fields should be present, in ADIF format (<https://adif.org/>)

While not required, you may also want to combine multiple operators' logs for stations within the same park and state, into a single log before submitting for upload. This will simplify the effort for the individual uploading the club's log.

Pay special attention to the fact that the Club's call sign is in the STATION_CALLSIGN field on every QSO, and the OPERATOR field is populated with the callsign of the individual who made that specific contact.

CALL	QSO_DATE	TIME_ON	BAND	MODE*	STATION_CALLSIGN*	OPERATOR*	MY_SIG	MY_SIG_INFO	SIG*	SIG_INFO*
<i>Worked Station</i>	<i>Date of QSO</i>	<i>Start time of QSO</i>	<i>Band</i>	<i>Mode</i>	<i>The club's Callsign*</i>	<i>The person who made this QSO</i>	<i>POTA</i>	<i>X-XXXX For the park you are in</i>	<i>POTA</i>	<i>X-XXXX For the park the other person is in, if this is a p2p contact</i>
N3VEM	20220513	225800	40m	ssb	K4Y TZ	AA4JW	POTA	K-9229	POTA	K-1425
W8TAM	20220513	230400	40m	ssb	K4Y TZ	AA4JW	POTA	K-9229		
W3AAX	20220513	230500	20m	ssb	K4Y TZ	W3SPC	POTA	K-9229		

* Mode should be detailed mode – i.e. ssb, FT8, etc. not Phone, Digital, etc.

* STATION_CALLSIGN and OPERATOR are sometimes omitted for individual logs, but MUST be included for a club log, as this is how we differentiate between the club (station) and the person making the contact (operator)

*SIG and SIG_INFO are only used if the contact is park-to-park.

5 Submitting the logs

At the time of the creation of this document, logs are submitted by sending an email to an address that is based on the number in the club's callsign. There should be 1 log per park and state. When sending in the logs, make sure the naming convention is followed, and that the club's callsign is included in the file name, so that it is clear that the log is for the club (i.e. K1UB@K-1234-20201127.adi)

0 calls – K0@parksontheair.com

1 calls – K1@parksontheair.com

2 calls – K2@parksontheair.com

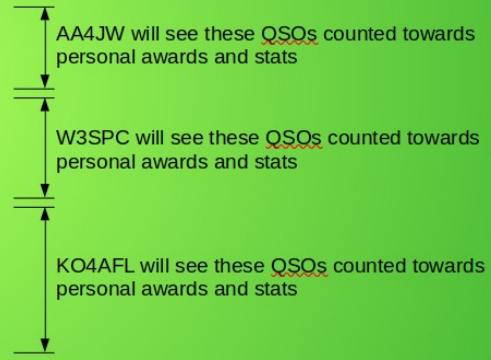
... through 9 calls

We are currently beginning testing on the self-uploading feature of the website. Once that feature is live, you will need to have the person that has access to your POTA account log in to the club's account, and upload the logs for the activation from the "My Log Uploads" section of the website.

6 How activation credit is awarded

Credit for the club works the same as it does for an individual, but as a bonus, and to encourage individuals to participate in club activations, any QSO where you are the operator for a club contact, will also be counted towards your own personal awards and stats:

CALL	QSO_DATE	TIME_ON	BAND	MODE*	STATION_CALLSIGN*	OPERATOR*
N3VEM	20220513	225800	40m	ssb	K4Y TZ	AA4JW
W8TAM	20220513	230400	40m	ssb	K4Y TZ	AA4JW
W3AAX	20220513	230500	20m	ssb	K4Y TZ	W3SPC
N0AW	20220513	230700	20m	ssb	K4Y TZ	W3SPC
KA8H	20220513	230800	20m	ssb	K4Y TZ	W3SPC
W7RTA	20220513	231000	40m	FT8	K4Y TZ	KO4AFL
WR5B	20220513	231200	40m	FT8	K4Y TZ	KO4AFL
KD5PCK	20220513	231200	80m	CW	K4Y TZ	KO4AFL
KB2FMH	20220513	231400	80m	CW	K4Y TZ	KO4AFL



The diagram illustrates how QSO credit is awarded based on the operator's call sign. It features three horizontal arrows pointing downwards, each spanning the width of the table. The first arrow is positioned between the first two rows (AA4JW as operator) and is labeled "AA4JW will see these QSOs counted towards personal awards and stats". The second arrow is between the third and fourth rows (W3SPC as operator) and is labeled "W3SPC will see these QSOs counted towards personal awards and stats". The third arrow is between the sixth and seventh rows (KO4AFL as operator) and is labeled "KO4AFL will see these QSOs counted towards personal awards and stats".

Nothing additional needs to be done for this credit to be recognized. The system does all the work, based on the log uploaded to the club's account – DO NOT upload copies of the log or individual QSOs to your personal account.

7 Special Considerations

7.1 QSO Uniqueness / Duplicates

The items that determine whether a QSO is a duplicate or unique are as follows:

<CALL> The station ‘hunting’ you

<QSO_DATE> UTC date

<BAND> band

<MODE> mode

<STATION_CALLSIGN> Club’s Callsign

<SIG_INFO> used if the person hunting you is also in a park – this is their park number

[LOCATION] This is not a field in your log, but it is a field that is chosen in the uploader when uploading your log. This indicates what state you were in, if the park crosses state lines. If you have operators who are in the same park, but in different states (i.e. Appalachian Trail, North Country Trail, Yellowstone, etc.) those qualify as unique QSOs.

7.2 Self-Working / Self Park-to-Park

The system prevents a callsign, either station or operator, from “working itself” – i.e. for a QSO, you cannot be both the station or operator and the worked callsign. This same logic applies to a club call, so if a club has multiple stations running, those stations cannot work each other for QSO or Park to Park credit.

7.3 Mic Passing

“Passing the Mic” is not part of a club activation. “Passing the Mic” is something that is done when multiple individuals are activating together, but not as a club, and each will be submitting their own logs.